

University: The University of Hong Kong (HKU)
Unit of Assessment (UoA): 13 – Computer Science / Information Technology
Title of case study: UTEE: A Secure, Efficient, and Portable Distributed Bigdata Computing System on Heterogeneous Trusted Execution Devices
Is this case study continued from a case study submitted in RAE 2020? N
1. Summary of the impact (indicative maximum 100 words) Prof. Heming Cui and his HKU PhD students invented UTEE (Ubiquitous Trusted Execution Environments), a novel software system for securing computing tasks on clouds. The key benefit of UTEE is that, it ensures that the big-data computing tasks, which are processing plaintext data, cannot be peaked or altered by two major types of malicious threats: (1) open-source operating systems (e.g., Ubuntu) developed by world-wide companies and individuals; and (2) malicious or careless cloud administrators. UTEE is commercialized as the essential runtime subsystem of Huawei's service, TICS (www.huaweicloud.com/product/tics.html) in 2021. Huawei's official appreciation letter (for short, 'Huawei letter') attached at the end of this document reveals that, UTEE has about 3 million active cloud and phone users (independent companies and individuals) located in 170 countries. In sum, regarding Prof. Cui as the principle investigator (leader of invention), his UTEE project has five indications of impact: (1) five HK-governmental grants (one RGC Research Impact Fund, three GRF, and one ITF, totally HK \$10.3 million), (2) four license-oriented grants from industry (totally HK \$7.8 million licensing fee), (3) 15 patent applications licenced to industry (13 applied in China and two applied in USA), (4) one HKU Knowledge Exchange Award (Engineering) in 2022, and (5) numerous media reports.
2. Underpinning research (indicative maximum 500 words) [Background of TEE] In this bigdata era, people usually conduct computations on sensitive user data (e.g., decrypted data) using bigdata computing software (e.g., Spark and Flink), and the computation tasks of each bigdata software are spitted and ran on a massive number of (heterogeneous) CPUs and GPUs in a public cloud (e.g., Amazon Cloud, Huawei Cloud, and Hospitals that conduct big-data computations). In recent years, a powerful and hardware-enforced security technique called TEE (Trusted Execution Environments), is introduced in high-end commercial CPU processors (e.g., Intel SGX and Arm TrustZone). TEE is a processor's special, tiny 'execution zone', which is physically isolated from the rest of the processor. When a bigdata task runs in a TEE, TEE's hardware protects the confidentiality and integrity of the task and data, strictly against the entire cloud software and people who have high software privileges, including malicious/flawed software (e.g., OS kernels with bugs) and malicious cloud administrators. Unfortunately, despite much effort from worldwide academia and industrial competitor systems (including Microsoft's VC3, European Union's SGX-Spark, UC Berkeley's Opaque, Google's Confidential Computing, and UNC's Civet), all existing TEE-relevant systems still faces three significant open research problems: (1) confirmed by all these competitor systems, TEE is still a low-level (assembly or C languages) programming object, so it is extremely hard to use by regular cloud software developers; (2) confirmed by our [Cronous ACM Micro 2022] paper in Section 3, TEE is only commercially available in some CPUs, but not in general GPUs; (3) revealed by our [Uranus ACM AsiaCCS 2020] paper in Section 3, existing competitors' TEE systems suffer from 20X~100X performance overhead compared to the native (insecure) bigdata computations, and cannot support typical big-data datasets (e.g., terabyte). To tackle these open problems, Dr' Cui's HKU team developed novel security techniques and integrate them as a new system called UTEE (Ubiquitous Trusted Execution Environments), including notable features below (with explicit evidence based on our three research papers,

two patents, and one grant, all listed in Section 3):

[1. Easy-to-program] UTEE is one of the world's first industrial-grade systems that support invoking **unmodified bigdata queries** (written in Java) in a TEE's isolated execution zone, including two pieces of impact evidence. **First**, our [Uranus ACM AsiaCCS 2020] paper and our [USA patent 1] takes the first step among all the published papers/reports about revealing that, all existing competitor systems before our paper's publication in Oct 2020, require intense and manual modifications on the bigdata queries (or even sometimes rewriting the entire bigdata queries from Java to C), in order to run these queries in any TEE-related processor. **Second**, the 1st paragraph of **Huawei letter** explicitly confirms that, 'UTEE (mainly, developed and patented from our Uranus paper) is a novel (i.e., first project in global industry) system combining the complementary advantages of the (TEE) hardware components and high-level programming languages (e.g., Java and Scala)'.

[2. Smallest trusted computing base (TCB)] In any security system, TCB means the set of all software and hardware components that must be assumed to be fully trusted and secure of the system; the small the TCB of a system, the more secure the system is. Our UTEE system has the smallest TCB among the competitor systems, with four pieces of impact evidence. **First**, claimed in our [Uranus AsiaCCS] paper and our [USA patent 1], because UTEE is the world's first work to support 'running only the bigdata queries (including all the decrypted data and sub-functions) within a CPU processor secure execution zone', and the rest of the cloud software (including OS and the big-data computing software which invoke the bigdata queries), are all made by UTEE automatically to run outside the execution zone, UTEE's TCB is around millions of lines of code smaller than all competitor systems. **Second**, explicitly quoted in the 3rd paragraph of **Huawei letter**, Huawei appreciated several novel techniques in UTEE, especially its 'low TCB', and so it is 'suitable to deploy on clouds, but also on personal computers and mobile phones'. **Third**, claimed in our [Cronus ACM Micro 2022] paper, UTEE requires only the CPU processors to contain TEE hardware, and UTEE is the first work to enable software-style-TEE in general GPUs (i.e., these GPUs' hardware do not need to support TEE). These three reasons make UTEE a unique system to support almost all world's general GPU brands, and UTEE being usable by Huawei's 3 million customers in 170 countries (this significant user base is confirmed in the third paragraph of **Huawei letter**). **Fourth**, about the low TCB and security, UTEE passed the China government's most rigor examinations and testing (see Media Report (5) in Section 5).

[3. Big-data friendly and Highest performance] Two pieces of impact evidence exist. **First**, the concrete evaluation results of our [Uranus AsiaCCS] paper and our [USA patent 1 and 2] claimed two facts:: (a) UTEE is world's first system that enables the TEE-enabled secure executions on typical bigdata datasets (e.g., terabyte on some typical bigdata queries and algorithms); (b) this size of dataset being able to run in UTEE (Uranus) is two or three orders of magnitudes larger than those datasets being able to run by competitor systems'. **Second**, praised in the 3rd paragraph of **Huawei letter**, Huawei explicitly praised that, UTEE has the novel technique of 'big-data aware high-performance processing'.

3. References to the research (indicative maximum of six references)

Period when the underpinning research was undertaken: 2021 to 2024

HKU PhD/MPhil students, who are primarily supervised by Prof. Cui, are marked with ' _ '.
Published referred research papers in international top venues on computing systems or security:

- (1) [**Cronus ACM Micro 2022**] Jianyu Jiang, Qi Ji, Tianxiang Shen, Xusheng Chen, Shixiong Zhao, Sen Wang, Li Chen, Gong Zhang, Xiapu Luo, and **Heming Cui**, CRONUS: Fault-isolated, Secure and High-performance Heterogeneous Computing for Trusted Execution Environments, Proceedings of the 55th ACM/IEEE International Symposium on

Microarchitecture. **ACM open source and results reproduced badge.**

- (2) [**Uranus ACM AsiaCCS 2020**] Jianyu Jiang, Xusheng Chen, Tzs On Li, Cheng Wang, Tianxiang Shen, Shixiong Zhao, **Heming Cui**, Co-Li Wang, and Fengwei Zhang, Uranus: Simple, Efficient SGX Programming and Its Applications, Proceedings of the 15th ACM ASIA Conference on Computer and Communications Security.
- (3) [**BIDL ACM SOSP 2021**] Ji Qi, Xusheng Chen, Yunpeng Jiang, Jianyu Jiang, Tianxiang Shen, Shixiong Zhao, Sen Wang, Gong Zhang, Li Chen, Man Ho Au, and **Heming Cui**, BIDL: A High-throughput, Low-latency Permissioned Blockchain Framework for Datacenter Networks, Proceedings of the 28th ACM Symposium on Operating Systems Principles. **ACM open source and results reproduced badge.**

Submitted patent applications to the USA federal government:

- (4) [**USA patent 1, about our Uranus (UTEE) system**] Jianyu Jiang, Xusheng Chen, Cheng Wang, **Heming Cui**, Sen Wang, Peng Wang, and Gong Zhang, Uranus: An Efficient, Secure Big-data Processing and Programming System based on TEE (USA Application No. 17975163, submitted in Oct 27, 2022).
- (5) [**USA patent 2, about our UPA system**] Tsz On Li, Jianyu Jiang, Ji Qi, Chi Chiu So, **Heming Cui**, Sen Wang, Peng Wang, Gong Zhang, UPA: An Automated, Accurate and Efficient Differentially Private Big-data Mining System (USA Application No. 18074972, submitted in Dec 05, 2022).

Hong Kong governmental innovation and industrial-oriented research grant:

- (6) [**HK ITC, Innovation and Technology Support Programme (ITSP), platform project**] **Heming Cui (PI)**, HKD \$3.3 million, June 2021 to May 2023, **UTEE: A Secure, Efficient, and Portable Distributed Bigdata Computing System on Heterogeneous Trusted Execution Devices** (Ref: GHP/169/20SZ).

4. Details of the impact (indicative maximum 750 words)

- (1) A preliminary prototype of UTEE (Ubiquitous Trusted Execution Environments), the proposed secure big-data system project, has commercially become the core system of Huawei Cloud's TICS (<https://www.huaweicloud.com/product/tics.html>) in Apr 2021.
- (2) Huawei's formal acknowledgement letter about the commercialization of UTEE (<https://hemingcui.github.io/doc/utee-ack.pdf>). This pdf letter comes with Huawei's corporate chop and its content is legally effective. This letter confirmed that, UTEE is already usable by Huawei Cloud's 3 million customers (including enterprises and individuals) in 170 countries.
- (3) Dr. Cui won the "**Best Collaborating Scientist Award Medal 2021**" of the Huawei Theory Research Department, who selects this award for the most-productive professor among their university collaborators around the world, including Europe/Canada/Asia (probably excluding USA/UK since 2019 due to diplomatic reasons). See the award notification email (<https://hemingcui.github.io/doc/2021-award.pdf>) on why the award goes to Dr. Cui; and see the picture of the medal in the ppt slides.
- (4) Dr. Heming Cui, the project coordinator (project leader recognized by RGC), "MindPipe: High-performance and Carbon-efficient Four-dimensional Parallel Training System for Large AI Models", RGC Research Impact Fund (Ref: R7030-22), HKD \$5.4 million, 2023 - 2026.
- (5) Dr. Heming Cui was awarded **three relevant HK governmental research grants** (Research Grant Councils General Research Funds, or **RGC GRF, all three grants as himself the PI**):
 - (1) "New Systems and Algorithms for Preserving Big-data Privacy in Clouds", GRF (Ref: 17202318), 2019~2022;
 - (2) "Micro-kernel Inspired Systems and Algorithms (MISA): Enabling Secure, Reliable and High-performance Micro-services on Public Clouds", GRF (Ref: 17208223), 2024~2027;
 - (3) "Achieving High-performance and Reliable Transaction/Analytical Processing in Edge Computing", GRF (Ref: 17204424), 2025~2028.
- (6) **HK ITC, ITSP Platform grant award** (an award letter is sent to HKU RSS and CS in May 2022, ref: GHP/169/20SZ). PI is Dr. Heming Cui. Grant title is "UTEE: A Secure, Efficient, and Portable Distributed Bigdata Computing System on Heterogeneous Trusted Execution

Devices”, the same as the title of this KE Award. Grant amount is HK \$3.3 million, including 10% of the amount donated from Huawei. Grant period is June 2022 to May 2024.

- (7) **HKU Faculty (Engineering) Knowledge Exchange Award** (there is only one award in every year, among the hundreds of faculty members in the Faculty of Engineering of HKU), July 2022, PI: Dr. Heming Cui, award title: “UTEE: A Secure, Efficient, and Portable Distributed Bigdata Computing System on Heterogeneous Trusted Execution Devices” (<https://www.ke.hku.hk/assets/doc/KEAward/2022/Engineering.pdf>)
- (8) Dr. Heming Cui was awarded **four relevant, technology-transfer-oriented research grant from Huawei**, all three grants as himself the PI, and paid from Huawei to HKU, with a total grant amount (licensing fee) of HK \$7.8 million: (1) "Architecture, Theory, and Algorithm Research for Accelerating Database Based on Accelerators", Huawei Theory Lab Flagship, HKD \$2.55 million, 2023~2025; (2) "ParaNAS: High-performance, Scalable, Reliable and High-precision Multi-GPU Pipeline Parallel DNN Training Systems", Huawei Theory Lab Flagship, HKD \$2.4 million, 2021~2023; (3) "A Blockchain-powered, Trustworthy Internet Layer (System) and its Decentralized and Efficient Applications", Huawei Innovation Research Program (HIRP) Flagship, HKD \$2.2 million, 2018~2021; (4) PI, "Achieving Strong Fault-tolerance for General Storage Applications via Fast, RDMA-powered PAXOS", Huawei Innovation Research Program (HIRP) Open, HKD \$0.6 million, 2017 - 2021.
- (9) **13 patents licensed to Huawei and applied for patents in China** (CN 202411227529.7, CN 202410650032.X, CN 202210138879, CN 202310158460.6, CN 202210138879.0, CN 202111372034.X, 92000692CN01, CN 2021101523346.3, CN 202111080651.2, CN 202010506698.X, CN 202110048599.6, CN 202010366539.4, CN 202010247629.1).

5. Sources to corroborate the impact (indicative maximum of 10 references)

- (1) HDC.Cloud 2021: “Huawei Releases Six Groundbreaking Products to Supercharge the Cloud and Intelligent Transformation of Business” (<https://www.huawei.com/en/news/2021/4/hdc-cloud-2021-six-products-cloud-intelligent-transformation>).
- (2) Global Times: “Huawei launches six new products to bolster growth in cloud sector” (<https://www.globaltimes.cn/page/202104/1222038.shtml>).
- (3) China Daily (中国日报): “华为云可信智能计算服务 TICS，安全释放数据价值” (<https://caijing.chinadaily.com.cn/a/202104/29/WS608a7f1ea3101e7ce974cf35.html>).
- (4) 中国证券报官方网站: “第三届上海金融科技国际论坛：强化数据安全 释放融合价值” (https://www.cs.com.cn/xwzx/hg/202112/t20211205_6225416.html).
- (5) China government testing and review report: “12 月 18 日，2020 数据资产大会在北京召开。会上，中国信息通信研究院为通过“基于可信执行环境的数据计算平台”的产品颁发证书。华为云可信智能计算服务 TICS 基于鲲鹏 TrustZone 机密计算，结合硬件 TEE 和软件 SMPC 算法，实现了软硬结合的计算加速，同时支持跨信任域的联邦 SQL 分析和联邦学习能力，以九大测试项全部通过，树立隐私计算产品的新标杆。” (<https://icode.best/i/87602637140406>).
- (6) The TelecomReview.com: “Huawei launches 6 new products to power up Cloud business. Trusted Intelligent Computing Service (TICS): HUAWEI CLOUD TICS provides security for innovative and converged applications of data elements, enabling secure data flow and maximizing data value.” (<https://www.telecomreview.com/articles/telecom-vendors/4880-huawei-launches-6-new-products-to-power-up-cloud-business>).
- (7) The Min.news (“頭條匯- 匯聚天下頭條”): “HUAWEI CLOUD Trusted Intelligent Computing Service TICS, Safely Unleash the Value of Data” (<https://min.news/en/tech/c1d269423d6459b3c61e4391179224e3.html>).

Huawei’s formal acknowledgement letter about the commercialization of UTEE (<https://hemingcui.github.io/doc/utee-ack.pdf>) is also attached in the next page of this form.

Letter of Appreciation for Contribution to Technical Cooperation Project

To whom it may concern,

I, on behalf of the Theory Lab, Huawei Technologies Co., Ltd, am writing to show our commercialization acknowledgement of UTEE (Ubiquitous Trusted Execution Environments): a secure, efficient, and portable distributed big-data computing system based on advanced CPU secure hardware components (e.g., ARM TrustZone and Intel SGX). UTEE is a novel eco-system combining the complementary security advantages of these hardware components and high-level programming languages (e.g., Java and Scala). UTEE can effectively prevent the computations and queries on plaintext data being peeked by diverse malicious parties on public clouds, including operating systems, hypervisors, and malicious/careless cloud administrators.

My research team in the Huawei Theory Lab has been looking for solutions of secure big-data computing systems built by world-wide leading universities and industries. In 2018, we offered a two-year flagship research fund of HK \$2,189,450 to Dr. Heming Cui on jointly developing such systems. From this research fund, we have conducted substantial collaborations with Dr. Cui and produced diverse research achievements, including jointly publishing a series of research papers in international top journals/conferences (e.g., TDSC, TPDS, EuroSys, DSN, SRDS, and Asia CCS) and applying for seven patents. Below are three selected papers and two selected patents relevant to secure big-data computing systems. UTEE is most relevant to the last patent.

- Uranus: Simple, Efficient SGX Programming and Its Applications, 15th ACM ASIA Conference on Computer and Communications Security (ASIACCS 2020).
- DAENet: Making Strong Anonymity Scale in a Fully Decentralized Network, IEEE Transactions on Dependable and Secure Computing (TDSC 2021).
- UPA: An Automated, Accurate and Efficient Differentially Private Big-data Mining System, 50th IEEE/IFIP International Conference on Dependable Systems and Networks (DSN 2020).
- An Automated, Accurate and Efficient Differentially Private Big-data Mining System, submitted to CNIPA, Ref. CN 202010506698.X.
- An Efficient, Secure Big-data Processing and Programming System based on Trusted Execution Environment, submitted to CNIPA, Ref. CN 202010366539.4.

UTEE is one major resultant system developed from our collaborations. Compared to UTEE's worldwide competitors (e.g., Alibaba, Baidu and Microsoft), we appreciate several unique novel techniques in UTEE, including its low trusted computing base, big-data aware high-performance processing, and portability across heterogenous CPU vendors. These unique techniques of UTEE make it not only be suitable to deploy on clouds, but also on personal computers and mobile phones. In April 2021, our Huawei Clouds CEO announced the release of Trusted and Intelligent Cloud Services (TICS, see <https://www.huaweicloud.com/product/tics.html>), and UTEE has been successfully deployed in TICS as a core system component. This means that UTEE is usable by the 3 million Huawei Clouds customers (enterprises and individuals) located in 170 countries.

Overall, we believe the recognition of Dr. Cui's achievements on your side will be a major encouragement of his future research on developing secure systems that are both academically innovative and commercially practical. These developments can contribute to the effective protection of data for many entities, including individuals, enterprises, organizations, and governments.

Bo Bai
Sincerely,

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